

ETRUSCANS

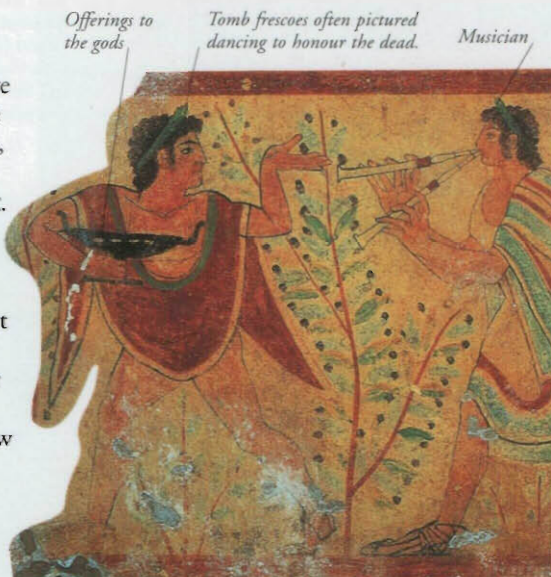


A PIRATE PEOPLE OF MYSTERIOUS ORIGIN, the Etruscans dominated the Mediterranean world from the 8th to the 4th centuries BC and formed a league of 12 city-states in what is now modern Tuscany, Italy. Though many of these cities – possibly the first in the area – have been lost over the centuries, superb painting and statuary remain. Etruscan fortunes, based on trade and conquest, started to decline after c.500 BC when the Romans, who had lived under Etruscan rule for a century, began to absorb their former masters into their own expanding empire.

Art

Vivid wall paintings have survived in tombs at the ancient cities of Orvieto, Veii, and Tarquinia – some dating to c.600 BC. Scenes often show dancing, religious observances, or the underworld. Etruscan art was influenced by the Greeks in subject matter and style, but as the Etruscan civilization grew it developed its own bold, colourful, and naturalistic style.

Wall painting, Tomb of the Leopard, Tarquinia



Cities of the dead

Rich Etruscans were buried in underground tombs, some of which were carved from the rock to resemble rooms. These cities of the dead contained frescoes, furniture, and lavish ornaments that tell us much about daily life.



Etruscan rock-cut tombs, Sovana

Bronze sculpture

The best sculptures were made in metal, especially bronze. Early sculptors made copies of imported Syrian or Phoenician objects, but then Greek styles became more popular.

Pan, the liveliest Greek god, in Etruscan style



Statuary

Etruscan craftworkers made statues of terracotta – a brownish-red, unglazed, fine pottery. The sculptors were particularly skilled at creating realistic human faces and figures, such as those at the precinct of Apollo in the city-state of Veii.



Etruscans adopted the letters of the Greek alphabet



Bronze coin

Language

Though examples of Etruscan writing survive on coins and tablets, the language remains a mystery. All scholars know is that it was the last survivor of those languages spoken before Indo-Europeans (from which all modern European languages descend) took over. The first six numbers were *mach, zal, thu, huth, ci, sa*, but no one can be certain which of them match the numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6.

Pirates and traders

For centuries Etruscan ships dominated the area of the Mediterranean called the Tyrrhenian Sea. Feared at first as pirates, they later turned to legitimate and prosperous trade with the Phoenicians, Greeks, and Egyptians. This continued until they were eclipsed by Rome.

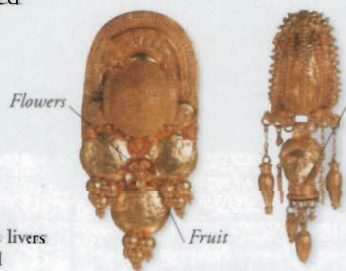
Fragment of marble statue



Sheep livers and cloud patterns were thought to reflect the will of the gods.

Trade

Etruscan agriculture, industry, and commerce all flourished in the period before the rise of Rome. Mineral deposits in the area were a great advantage to the Etruscans. Wealthy merchants traded metal products, such as jewellery and bronze figurines, as far away as Scandinavia and England.



Gold earrings

Etruscan jewellers were especially good goldsmiths, and surviving pieces show originality and artistry. Much gold jewellery was made for trade with Greece.



Gold wreath hair ornament

Relationship with Rome

The last Etruscan king was overthrown in 510 BC, as Rome took over the Etruscan cities one by one. Many practices, such as predicting the future by studying sheep entrails, lived on in the new Roman republic. Leading Roman families were proud of their Etruscan ancestry.



City people

No one can be sure exactly which 12 walled cities formed the original Etruscan league. Ancient walls still surround modern Tuscan hill-towns, such as Cerveteri. The original cities were built haphazardly, and each was dominated by temples.

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